

Upekkha Foundation Report - 2025



Embracing Karm Yog

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Vision Statement

"To cultivate inner growth for young leaders through selfless service."

This vision reflects the organization's core belief that community development and personal evolution are inseparable. Upekkha Foundation operates from the conviction that young people, when provided with purposeful engagement opportunities within authentic community contexts, develop the wisdom, empathy, and strategic capability required for sustained leadership in social change.

Mission Statement

"Embracing Karm-Yog"

The organization's mission is grounded in two foundational principles:

Karm (The Power of Action):

Engagement in strategic, evidence-informed action that creates measurable improvements in community conditions. Service is neither passive charity nor well-intentioned volunteerism, but deliberate intervention designed to address root causes and create systems-level change.

Yog (Uniting with Purpose):

Service conducted with recognition of inherent human dignity and potential. This principle acknowledges that empowerment is not a gift bestowed but a capacity expressed through facilitating communities' own agency and capability development.



Organization's Background

Upekkha Foundation represents an emerging model of youth-led social change rooted in the conviction that young leaders, when strategically positioned within community systems, can catalyze meaningful improvements in both individual lives and organizational ecosystems.

The organization was founded in recognition of a fundamental insight: India's development sector, despite robust policy frameworks at national and state levels, suffers from significant implementation gaps that leave underprivileged communities without access to quality infrastructure. These gaps are not policy failures but coordination failures: multiple actors work in isolation, evidence remains siloed, and systemic levers for change go unused.

Upekkha Foundation's response to this challenge has been to position itself as the organization that bridges these gaps: synthesizing existing evidence, convening dispersed actors, and facilitating **strategic advocacy toward meaningful policy change**.

Disclaimer

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Overview

Gurugram (2023–2024): Environmental initiatives, food donation coordination, support for blind homes; developed volunteer and operational systems.

Pune (2024–2025): Shifted focus to surplus food redistribution and education outcomes through NGO collaborations and policy-linked assessments. Project Astitva was launched during this phase.

Initiative 1: Surplus Food Redistribution

Builds partnerships with restaurants and caterers to redirect surplus quality food to underserved communities.

Milestones (2024–2025):

- Implemented a low-cost, hyper-local model for operational efficiency.
- Delivered over 850+ meals and grains to underprivileged communities in Pune (Gokhale Nagar, Model Colony, Shivaji Nagar, Kothrud).
- Trained volunteers about food security protocols, and local outreach.
- Created teams and team leaders for procurement, and safe distribution.



Initiative 2: Children's Education Partnerships

Conducted structured needs assessments at multiple NGO and community schools.

Milestones (2024–2025):

- Conducted primary qualitative research for assessing the educational needs of Akshar Paaul, Majha Ghar NGO, Ramkrishna Math
- Key Findings:
 - Students demonstrate intelligence and strong academic motivation
 - Faculty are qualified but face resource constraints
 - Resource limitations restrict provision of learning materials
- Recommendations Developed:
 - Mentorship programs connecting volunteers with students
 - Workshops on gender equality and inclusive dynamics
 - Collaborative fundraising for resource provision



Project Astitva: Public Health Initiative

Create a lasting, systemic impact in Pune's public education ecosystem through research-backed interventions and public-policy influence.

What Has Been Done So Far:

- Reached out to NGOs and government schools for collaboration and field access.
- Conducted 4–5 field visits for surveys, classroom observations, and student/teacher interviews.
- Designed a custom 4–6 week learning module delivered on Sundays in NGO schools.
- Planned for 4 collaborators, but completed a full cycle for one NGO due to operational limitations.
- Built strong primary data, but limited secondary research and insufficient scale for policy influence.

Strategic Pivot Needed:

To achieve the policy objective, Project Astitva must shift from program delivery to research and pilot scalable model along with policy engagement.



Acknowledgments

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Our Team

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Advisors & Mentors

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Advisor: Jyotsana Bhatnagar, Ex-CSR Head Castrol

Advisor: Kasturi Thorat, M.Sc. Policy

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Contributor: Rohit Narang, Founder: Tossin Pizza

Contributor: Sunil Rajagopal, Associate, Royal Enfield, India.

Partner Organizations

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Volunteers

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